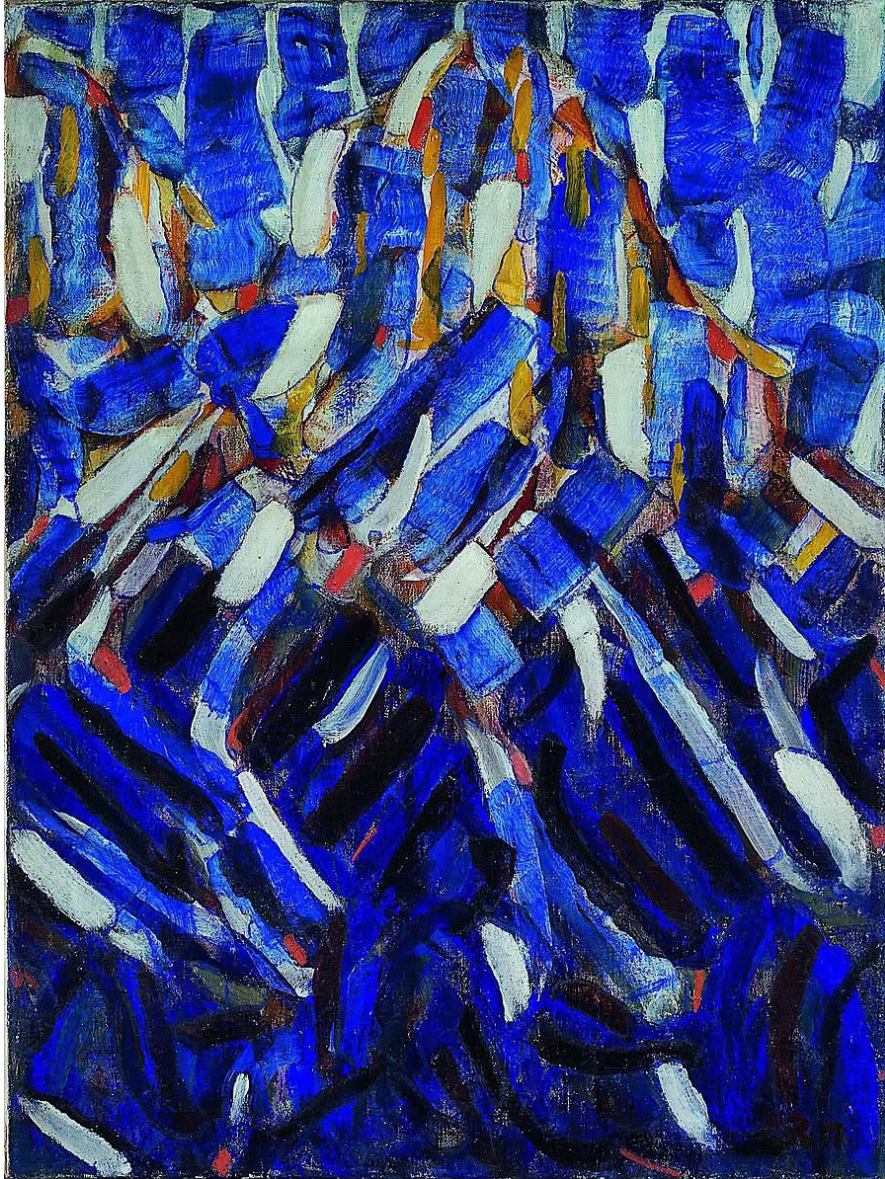


FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Epiphany 7
The Light of In-Couraging
15 February 2026



"The Blue Mountain, 1912" by Christian Rohlfs
Museum Kunstpalast, Düsseldorf

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Agatha Teague, Guest Organist

Ballo del Granduca - Jan Pieterszoon Sweelinck (1562-1621)

Prelude and Fugue in A minor, BWV 543 - J.S. Bach (1685-1750)

Adoration - Florence Price (1887-1954)

Prélude sur l'Introït de l'Épiphanie - Maurice Duruflé (1902-1986)

Fugue sur le thème du Carillon des heures de la cathédrale de Soissons –
Maurice Duruflé (1902-1986)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Rev. Fregin & Sarah Fuhrmeister

As we greet the morning
amid the gleam of a new day,
faintly we discern the possibilities
that lay before us.

Energy rising,
plans turning to action,
we build our yesterday
from the living of our days.

May we live our hope into tomorrow.
May we wrap our lives around the challenges of today
that we might be spent in the effort
of bringing this world to a place of peace and justice.

And in the quiet of our worship,
may we listen at the center of our being
for the truth of our inner voice,
one that is not stilled, but still,
and that sets before us
the purpose of this day.

*As those who remain attentive to the mystery,
we bring all that we have
and all that we are
into this time of worship.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering** *The Sun is on the Sea and Shore*

BROTHER JAMES' AIR

The sun is on the sea and shore, a new day has begun;
With morning hymns we will adore the blessed Three-in-One;
And we shall praise you ever more, until the day is done.

Your love is ever in our view, like shining stars by night;
Your gifts are every morning new, O God of love and light;
Your mercy, like the heaven's blue, fills all our dazzled sight.

We do not know what grief and care each coming day may bring;
The heart shall find some gladness there that trusts you in each thing;
The life that serves you everywhere will never cease to sing.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Fregin

Holy One,
in the living of this day,
may we find the courage to let go of our fears,
accept the challenges before us
and open ourselves
to the still, small voice
we know to be grounded in holiness.

May our souls be filled
with the awe of who we are called to be.

*As those who seek after the light,
yet stand within its glowing, we pray.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

"Good Trouble"
Cathedral Choir

THOMAS KEESECKER

***The Lord's Prayer**

Sarah Fuhrmeister

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.*

*And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Fregin

When the path is simple, peace.
When the way is complicated, peace.
May Christ not only show us the way
but also *be* the way we travel:
in our way of blessing, on our way to peace. [jadpt/richardson]

May the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition *from the Gospel of Matthew, chapter 5* **Sarah Fuhrmeister**

You are the salt in the land.
What if salt is ruined because of thoughtless handling?
How can it be re-salted?
It no longer has any purpose other than to throw it outside to be trampled on by people.

You are the light of the world.
A city built on a hill cannot be hid.
People do not light a lamp and put it under the bushel basket;
rather, they put it on the lampstand,
and it gives light to all in the house.

In the same way, let your light shine before others,
so that they may see your good works
and give glory to God in heaven.

This is the Gospel of Love and Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

O Spirit of God,
found in wind and flame—
you whip up our sometimes humdrum lives
from out of their complacency!
You fall upon us in unexpected moments:
turning our grief into laughter;
our confusion into motivation.
You surround us in our rush of activities
and settle upon us in our stillness.
And, in all, you ever entwine
your Holy Breath with our breath.

You surround us even now, O Spirit,
offering us peace for our lives,
pushing us out of our comforts,
healing us with your hope,
loving us –
for you are One, O God of delight and justice:
you are the movement of our lives
as we seek to embody your peace on this earth.

*You, O God, are the power behind our every deed and word,
you are the peace that lasts
forever and ever.*

For this and so much more,
we give you our thanks.
Amen and Amen!

Meditation Anthem

“Lord’s Prayer”
Laude, Scott Graff, *Leader*

DUKE ELLINGTON

Sermon

The Light of In-Couraging

Rev. Michael Lehman

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Fregin

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they’re given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

“God, Make Me An Instrument”
Cathedral Choir

ROGER HOLLAND II

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator’s praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Sarah Fuhrmeister

God of Faithfulness,
in every age you call people
to make your love known.
May we who celebrate in this sacred place today,
find the courage to listen once again
for your call on each of our lives,
and then, may we have the strength and the courage
to share your grace and goodness
with all your children.

May it always be so, O God.
May it always be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

That all that confines us
will fall away.
*That we will lose ourselves
into the love of God
with devotion and desire.*
That we may know the way
that makes for peace
in our souls and in this world.
*That we will give our lives
to its path.* [jrichardson]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Choral Response

"Wade In The Water"
Cathedral Choir

TRADITIONAL NEGRO SPIRITUAL

***Hymn for the Journey**

Creative Love

TALLIS' CANON

Creative love, our thanks we give
That this our world, is incomplete,
That struggle greets our will to live,
That work awaits our hands and feet.

That we are not yet fully wise,
That we are in the making still -
As friends who share one enterprise
And strive to blend with nature's will.

What though the future long delay,
And still with faults we daily cope?
It gives us that for which we pray,
A field for toil and faith and hope.

Since what we choose is what we are,
And what we love we yet shall be,
The goal may ever shine afar -
The will to reach it makes us free.

-lyrics by W.W. Hyde

Postlude

Agatha Teague, *Guest Organist*

Improvisation on CWM Rhonda - Paul Manz

Inside The Music

"I didn't know this version of Duke Ellington's "Lord's Prayer" until Scott brought it to my attention. Ellington wrote around 60 choral pieces in addition to all of the iconic jazz band, solo, and piano pieces he gave us. At first listen, the simple homophonic choral setting with some jazzy-sounding harmonies seemed an apt, yet perhaps humble, statement for one of the masters of 20th century composition. As I got to know it, I realized the depths of its hidden riches. The homophony and careful voice leading coupled with a well-known text give our ears a sense of determined motion that makes it easy to miss the wisdom he encodes in his signature harmonic language. The song begins and ends in C major, and there are ten total C major chords on the words: Our, Father, Heaven, name, Earth, Heaven, Thine, glory, ever, and amen. You can begin to see the poetry of his architecture without knowing anything else. What he hangs upon that architecture reflects a confident, but clear-eyed statement of faith. Of the remaining 67 chords, 20 of them are diminished seventh chords. That's 25% of the chords in the piece. Most choral pieces don't even have one diminished seventh chord. A fully diminished seventh chord contains four minor thirds. There are only three unique versions of this chord in music (trinitarians perked up?). By one account, it is the most dissonant chord in music. By another account, it's the most versatile. Four minor thirds separates the octave into exactly equal portions. That means that travel to any other chord can be achieved through two or more half steps. Half step voice leading creates a strong ear bond between two chords. Diminished 7th chords were used by multiple mid-20th-century composers because they have a way of limiting tonality's authority in a composition. A new, situational, hierarchy emerges. A quarter of the chords in his "Lord's Prayer" are tonally ambiguous, transition smoothly to and from another chord, and give him a chance to recreate how people hear authority. The result of this ambiguous glue leads to contemplations similar to those found in its text. Jesus regularly responded to the profound injustice of the world he lived in. When he taught his friends how to pray using the Lord's Prayer, he juxtaposed his prayer's simplicity with people who used prayer to draw public attention to themselves. He said that if they wanted to center themselves on the light most important in life, to remember that divinity beyond our understanding flows through the world. Equally, a compassionate response to life is one in which we take one moment at a time and avoid causing harm to ourselves or others. Jesus encourages prayer that draws the speaker back into themselves and into relationship with the divine. Ellington, too, lived in a profoundly unjust world into which he chose to share a bright light. His musical contribution to this prayer asks us to consider the systemic oppression that we have learned to accept by revealing our capacity to think and live beyond it. His diminished seventh chords aren't ambiguity. They are movement and potential. They are the slip between our intentions and our actions. They are the opportunity to lean into compassion, and the capacity to change course as we recall with humility our relationship to the divine. They are the Spirit acting upon us when we are open to receive it. Another interesting harmonic relationship begins and ends the piece, and can be found on the words Father, Heaven (both times) and amen. He uses a D flat

dominant 7th chord adjacent to the C major chord that centers the piece. D flat dominant 7 is the primary complimentary chord to G flat major. G flat major a tritone away from C major. The tritone is known as “El Diablo” or “The Devil’s interval” in medieval theory. That medieval assignment of perceived evil to an interval is well known in contemporary musical circles. It also happens that for jazz musicians, the tritone has a very different meaning and understanding. Tritones are the butter that connects jazz harmonies and allows for their complexity to sing to our ears. Ellington knew all too well what to do with a tritone. In this dramatic moment where he questions authority, the image of the perceived power of evil leaps in the ear. In his new hierarchy, Ellington asks if we will allow ourselves to be tempted away from our center. He was also using his well-honed jazz sensibilities to create a smoothly complex musical moment. The final time he uses this C to Db7 chord combination appears on the last two chords of the piece on “amen.” This time, though, he puts C major’s dominant of G in the bass note. This is one of only two times the dominant (C’s primary complimentary) appears in the piece. The first one is on “Heaven.” Here at the end, it arrives just when we need the confidence to believe that we were justified in adhering to compassion’s principles and a belief in the divine. That profound life question is articulated by a single note on the penultimate chord after a meandering experience. Ellington captures the essence of life in this small, but elegant piece, just as Jesus captures it in his small, but elegant, prayer. In the midst of complexity, we can rely on compassion and humility to illuminate the potential for us to relate to life and light outside of the limitations of authority systems, and thereby connect with the divine.” ~ Dr. David Harris